

spend on gifts. Then I determine a budget for each person using my Christmas Gift Budget Worksheet, which helps me stay on track throughout the season. You can download a copy at

CreativeSavingsBlog.com/ExpenseResources

READER TIP:

I shop year-round for Christmas gifts—starting for the next year almost as soon as this Christmas is over. That way, I can take my time and find great deals on gifts that I know my family will love.

—Kristen, JoyfullyThriving.com

This strategy is similar to the 52-Week Savings Plan that you may have seen floating around the web or on Pinterest, but instead of the gradual savings increase throughout the year, my method focuses on a fixed amount from January to December. It's much more practical, and creates the savings habit that a gradual increase cannot. Plus, you can customize it to the exact amount you want to save by the end of the year!

Here's an example of how much you could save if you set aside the following amounts every week starting in January:

\$10/week = \$470 by December

\$20/week = \$940 by December

\$30/week = \$1,410 by December

Each of these savings plans is available as a downloadable worksheet at CreativeSavingsBlog.com/ExpenseResources. You'll also find a completely custom plan if you'd like to save a different amount from the ones mentioned above.

2. GET CREATIVE WITH GIFTS